Student-Athlete and Entrepreneur: Connor O'Brien builds his future on and off the field

Image: Luke Smith and Lute Connor O'Brien '27, student-athletes and co-founders of 360 Home Services.

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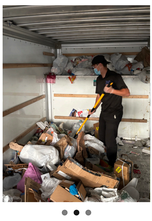
By Britt Board
Assistant Director of Communications

PLU junior Connor O'Brien '27 has a lot on his plate. He's a student-athlete, business owner, and business major (finance concentration) with a data science minor. But for him, each role fuels the others.

When he's not in class or on the field as a midfielder for the PLU soccer team, Connor is running 360 Home Services LLC, a home maintenance company he co-founded with friend Luke Smith.

"I wasn't a good high school student, but I really found my place during college," Connor shares. "Now I'm in my third year on the soccer team — a midfielder. I train four times a week, play two games a week, and work with athletic trainers to strengthen and recover from injuries. Plus, I run the business."

Off the field, Connor is studying finance with a minor in data science. "I started in marketing, but it didn't feel right. I have always wanted to start my own business, ever since I was a kid, mowing people's lawns. I want to do a whole lot of different things over the course of my life."



Launching 360 Home Services

That entrepreneurial energy led Connor and his friend Luke Smith (a fellow student-athlete attending Linfield University) to co-found 360 Home Services LLC, a home maintenance company based in Sammamish. "Me and Luke were training together and came up with the idea," Connor said. "We have a mentor and PLU alum who guided us through the process. He's been training me in soccer since 7th grade."

That mentor is Surafel ("Surf") Wodajo '12, a PLU soccer alum who now works in sales at Smartsheet. "Surf held the all-time assist record at PLU up until last year," Connor says. "He would help out coaching a small team I played for in 6th and 7th grade. He took me and one other player aside and offered to train us for free, because he saw potential in us. He just cared about giving back to the community."

Connor and Surf have stayed close ever since. "He suggested that we make a service that does it all." That idea turned into 360 Home Services — a one-stop shop for gutter cleaning, power washing, window washing, and more. "I do the stuff people don't want to do," Connor says. "I love seeing the before and after." In just two months of operations last summer, the business completed over 100 jobs and hired nine employees (all local college students). They're currently scheduling services for spring 2026.

Partnership and mentorship

Connor credits his success not only to Surf's mentorship but also to the partnership he's built with Luke. Luke said the connection was instant. "We were paired by our mutual mentor, Surf, who saw our shared drive to grow, improve, and compete," Luke says. "Once we stepped into business, the story was the same. I never have to question if Connor is giving his all. We complement each other perfectly, not only in our unique skills and personality traits, but in the shared values that enable them."

Balancing soccer, school, and business isn't easy, but Luke says they see it all as part of the same journey. "The truth is that in business, if you're playing with 'balance,' you're playing to lose," he says. "When I'm at school, I don't separate the two; I approach both as gaining knowledge, skills, and experiences that will turn me into the person I want to be."

Support from PLU faculty and family

Connor says the PLU faculty have been an essential part of his growth as a student and entrepreneur. "I can ask them questions that don't relate to class," he says. "They are helpful in life and entrepreneurship."

He especially enjoys a business law class with Professor Ralph Flick. "He's a super nice, fun, outgoing guy. The way he structures the class is different. It's not a class where you just sit there."

Outside of PLU, Connor credits his mom, Julie O'Brien, for his work ethic and some of his handyman skills. "My mom taught me everything," he shares. "She's always been self-sufficient."

> *I enjoy PLU from top to bottom — the faculty, the students. My family loves PLU, too.*

Finding His Place

Even with everything he's juggling, Connor says the PLU community keeps him grounded. "My teammates are my brothers," he reflects. "I enjoy PLU from top to bottom — the faculty, the students. My family loves PLU, too."

And when asked what his alumni referral scholarship (a bonus from his connection to Surf) means to him, his answer comes easily: "It means a lot. Helps me pursue a higher education and grow to be my best self in a place that I love."

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